

RAISING THE STAKES
(L–R) Union ministers Narendra Singh Tomar, Prahlad Singh Patel and Faggan Singh Kulaste

in power in the state and the main Opposition in Chhattisgarh, a win in either state won't come easy. While the party's first list mostly covered the seats where it has had a lacklustre performance, the second list made one thing clear—it is leaving nothing to chance. The big names in the fray include Union ministers Narendra Singh Tomar (Dimani), Prahlad Singh Patel (Narsingpur) and Faggan Singh Kulaste (Niwas). The party has also fielded Lok Sabha MPs Riti Pathak (Sidhi), Ganesh Singh (Satna), Rakesh Singh (Jabalpur Paschim) and Rao Uday Pratap Singh (Gadarwara), besides BJP national general secretary Kailash Vijayvargiya (Indore-1).

While a few big names were expected to be announced, the scale at which it has been done has left everyone surprised. In the past, even Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, who was then the Vidisha MP, was fielded against sitting Congress CM Digvijaya Singh from the Raghogarh seat in 2003. But he lost that election. More recently, in West Bengal, the party fielded five MPs in 2021, though only two could win. The party experimented with it in Kerala and Uttar Pradesh too, but without any success.

So, what is the BJP's thinking behind this move in MP? It's a two-pronged strategy, say those privy to the party's inner workings. One, keeping the four-time CM Chouhan, who is facing severe anti-incumbency, down to scale, if not exactly in the shade. Two, mobilising support for candidates in seats adjoining the ones from where these senior leaders are in the fray.

The Jan Ashirwad Yatra—held before every election to galvanise party workers—was divided into five phases, each led by different leaders, Chouhan not among them. The BJP central leadership has also avoided declaring Chouhan as the CM face. Now, by fielding its top leaders as candidates, it has kept them in the race for the top post in case the party wins. Tomar, who is contesting from Dimani in Morena district, is expected to have a positive impact on other seats in the Gwalior-Chambal belt. Just as Vijayvargiya's candidature from Indore, the party hopes, will improve its chances in the Malwa region and veteran tribal leader Faggan Singh's in the tribal belt of Mahakoshal. "When my candidature was announced, I was surprised too," says Vijayvargiya. "But being a loyal soldier of the party, I will do whatever it wants me to."

The Congress is keenly observing these developments, while keeping its cards close to its chest. Its leaders feel the BJP has pressed the "panic button", sensing a certain defeat. State Congress president Kamal Nath took to X (previously Twitter) to declare that the BJP's candidate list belies and undermines the Chouhan's government's claims of development over the past 15 years. On his own party's failure to come out with a list, the former CM says, "We have already unofficially informed the candidates who have been finalised. They have started working in their constituencies." Is it possible that the BJP has taken the Congress by surprise too? ■

BATTLE FOR CHHATTISGARH

A COMMON STRATEGY

- Just like in Madhya Pradesh, the BJP was first off the mark in Chhattisgarh, coming out with a list of 21 candidates on August 17
- The names include Durg MP **Vijay Baghel** (inset, right) from Patan, which Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel represents
- The 21 seats are the ones where the BJP is relatively weak, and it wants to give its candidates ample time to reach out to the electorate
- It will also give the party a chance for course-correction if there's any negative feedback
- The BJP has eight Lok Sabha members from the state, besides Durg MP. Some of them could also get a ticket
- Like in MP, the Congress has yet to declare its candidates. Internal surveys point to anti-incumbency against many of its 71 sitting MLAs, though not against the CM. He remains popular and the party's main draw
- But the Congress, say insiders, wants to have a mitigation plan in place in case of a rebellion from the MLAs who fail to make the cut

